BACKGROUND SECURITY COUNCIL

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Introduction

"Cultural Genocide in Occupied or Colonized Territories"

Greeting delegates, on behalf of the Instituto Oriente, the Academy of English, and the Secretariat, we, as Chair, welcome you to the 16th edition of Model United Nations Instituto Oriente 2026.

We, as the Chair of the Security Council, are pleased to have you on this committee and are highly honored to guide you along this journey. We, as president, secretary, and moderator, are convinced that the information provided in this document will be useful to enrich your arguments and strengthen your posture.

We, as a Chair, chose this topic because it is important to be informed about this subject and above all to discuss it to form a critical thinking about the current world circumstances.

Cultural genocide is a term coined by the lawyer Raphael Lemkin, who defined it as the intentional and systematic eradication of the values, language, traditions, and other elements that constitute the culture of social groups, without the need to physically eliminate them. Unlike conventional genocide, this one aims to exterminate identity and erase what differentiates them from others. Causing the disintegration of the social fabric, loss of diversity, and an identity crisis for future generations.

This phenomenon has been recurrent in the history of mankind, with tragic examples such as the conquest of the Aztec empire, the Armenian genocide, and the Holocaust as some of the many cases that have gone unpunished.

From the forced assimilation of the indigenous people in colonized regions of America, Africa, and Australia to the destruction of the

Palestinian cultural heritage in the occupied territories, with the aim of destroying the cultural identity of entire communities. This systematic cultural annihilation is not only useful for dominance but also to weaken resistance, impose submission, and rewrite history in favor of the oppressor.

A current case of cultural genocide is that Tibetan children as young as four years old are sent to Chinese state boarding schools for indoctrination. They have been beaten for praying and wearing Buddhist blessing cords, forced to sleep in sheepskins, and taught only in Mandarin.

Having in mind all the consequences and injustices that this situation causes, we, as a Chair, would like to highlight that it is essential to address this problem in order to find realistic and innovative solutions.

The following document will provide you with information about the controversial points and the purpose of discussing this topic.

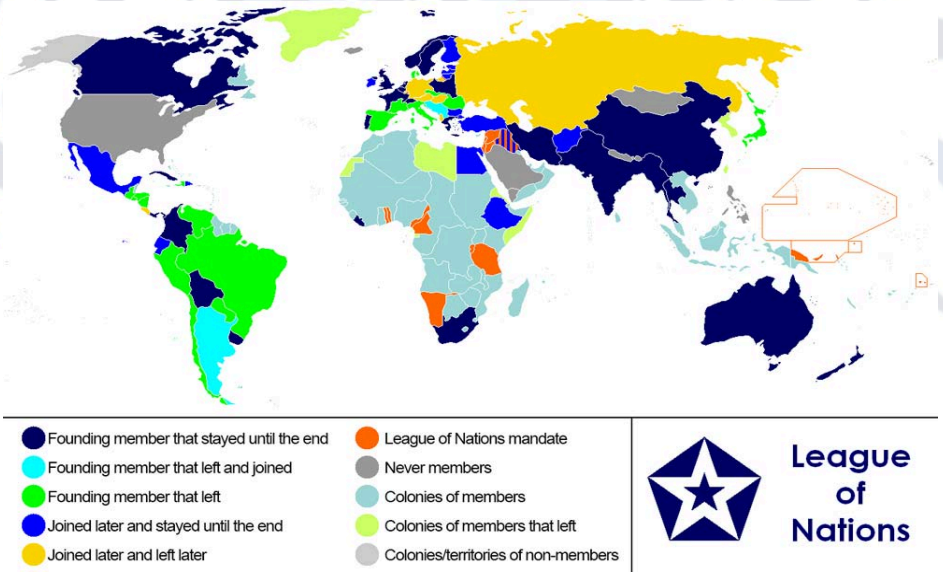
History of the Committee

Function

To quote the United Nations, "the Security Council has the primary responsibility for the maintenance of international peace and security." It is the committee with one of the most decision-making authorities within the United Nations.

Origins

The first vision of the United Nations was created in 1941 by Winston Churchill, after the dissolution of the "League of Nations" caused by the "Second World War". Then, the "four policemen" constituted by the United States, the United Kingdom, the Soviet Union, and China, allied forces, and in 1945, the United Nations Charter was signed.
American President Franklin D. Roosevelt and British Prime Minister
The Security Council (SC) was born with other four main organs (among them the General Assembly, the Secretariat, the International Court of Justice, and the Economic and Social Council); it had its first session on 17 January 1946, at Church House, Westminster, in London.



Objectives of the United Nations

Since the United Nations (UN) was created, it has had four principal objectives that all of the organs must follow: to maintain international peace and security, to develop friendly relations among nations, to cooperate in solving international problems and in promoting respect

for human rights, and to be a center for harmonizing the actions of nations.

Objective and Mechanisms of the Security Council

The mission of the organ is to identify potential threats and to find peaceful settlements; in order to achieve this objective, the SC is allowed to impose sanctions in an effort to pressure those who are punished. Some of the actions the organ may carry out if a dispute leads to hostilities are: issue ceasefire directives, dispatch military observers to help reduce tensions, impose economic sanctions, severance of diplomatic relations, or even collective military action.

These measures are reflected in the resolutions, the document in which the opinions of the organ are expressed. This document is divided into two parts: the preamble and the operative part. The preamble establishes the criterion, which serves as a basis for making decisions, and the operative part expresses the solutions or measures that the organ will carry out if approved.

Members of the organ

The Security Council is constituted by five permanent countries that have the right to veto (People's Republic of China, United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland, Russian Federation, United States of America, and French Republic); and ten non-permanent countries, which are rotated every two years, also do not have the right to veto. This right consists of the capacity to revoke any resolution or decision of the organ.

Representation

According to Article 28 of the Charter of the United Nations, every member of the organ should be represented at the meetings by a permanent accredited representative. The Security Council has a total of 15 permanent representatives. However, in obedience to Article 39 of the Provisional Rules of Procedure, the organ may invite people who are considered competent for the purpose, in order to give assistance with information on the topic that is being discussed.

Recent topics discussed by the Council

Some of the most important topics that the Security Council has discussed recently are: United States bombing of Iran's nuclear facilities, Peace and security in Africa, prevention of a catastrophic escalation between Iran and Israel, Russian aerial attacks in Kyiv, Ukraine, Diplomatic discussions for Viable Political Horizon in Gaza, International Residual Mechanism for Criminal Tribunals in the Kingdom of Belgium, among many others.

Long term

Although Raphael Lemkin had already introduced the term "genocide" in 1944 in his book: "Axis Rule in Occupied Europe", it was not until the adoption of the Genocide Convention in 1948 that this concept was recognized as an international crime. However, despite Lemkin's emphasis on cultural destruction, the final text of the Convention excluded cultural genocide as a punishable act, instead focusing exclusively on physical and biological forms of extermination.

Nevertheless, the policymakers have been debating whether the crimes related to cultural genocide can be interpreted within the frameworks of the Genocide Convention, since this kind of felony is diverse in practice, being that it is not always physically violent.

That is why the Genocide Convention and UN Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples and the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights were created, so the cultural identity remained protected. Nevertheless, over the years, these documents have demonstrated their lack of effectiveness, given that it has no legal support in the affected countries.

Cases

Since the Chinese invasion in 1949, the Tibetan people have been suffering from cultural repression. Actions like the destruction of monasteries, forced relocation of nomadic communities, imposition of the Chinese language, and restrictions on religious practice have been carried out. Unfortunately, despite the international resolutions, there are still no mechanisms to sanction the Chinese government for the policies it has taken.

For over 100 years (1880-1996), the Canadian government sent more than 150,000 indigenous children to boarding schools, where they suffered from many kinds of abuses: thousands died from malnutrition or poorly treated illnesses, they were forbidden to speak their native language and to carry out

their spiritual practices. Years later, in 2008, the Truth and Reconciliation Commission of Canada (TRC) was created as a way to investigate the case and achieve reconciliation. However, this initiative did not manage to impose any kind of punishment.

Social Impact

One of the main long-term social consequences of cultural genocide is the disintegration of the social fabric and loss of cultural identity. This rupture leaves future generations vulnerable to external influences, weakening their sense of belonging and contributing to long-term mental health challenges. It also leads to the marginalization of affected populations and reinforces ongoing cycles of exclusion, inequality, and social fragmentation.

Economic impact

The displacement and marginalization of culturally targeted communities often result in systemic inequality in sectors such as education, employment, and essential services. Barriers that force individuals to accept low-paying or unstable jobs and limit their ability to accumulate wealth or pursue professional opportunities. Over time, enduring cycles of poverty and preventing progressive social mobility gradually reduce the quality of life of entire generations.

Short term

In recent years, intentional destruction of cultural heritage and erasure of identity have been issues of concern for the global community. From bombardment of religious and historic targets in Gaza and Sudan to state suppression of cultural expression in the likes of Xinjiang and Crimea, global surges in cultural targeting have cautioned against a perilous path.

Although the term "cultural genocide" is not formally defined in international law, the United Nations Security Council has acknowledged that the destruction of cultural heritage can be an international peace and security threat. One resolution (2347) sets out that attacks against cultural property can be a prosecutable "war crime" and that preservation of cultural heritage is an essential part of precluding future conflict and reconciliation following conflict.

In the last five years, UN agencies have documented extensive destruction of cultural heritage in conflict situations, made emergency protection measures, and helped attempts at legal responsibility through the International Criminal Court and the International Court of Justice.

This Council is therefore to address how cultural destruction not only goes against global norms, but also further destabilizes, radicalizes, and undermines movement towards sustainable peace. The representatives are to discuss the question of how the UN Security Council can strengthen near-term measures to prevent, respond to, and bring to justice the perpetrators of acts of cultural erasure constituting or contributing to genocide.

Cases

In Australia, Indigenous people remain vulnerable to cultural genocide. The destruction of Juukan Gorge by mining company Rio Tinto in 2020, which razed a 46,000-year-old sacred Aboriginal site, provoked global outrage and ongoing debates about the exposure of Indigenous heritage to industrial interests. Despite legislative and corporate reforms that followed, Aboriginal groups continue to report desecration of traditional landscapes, exclusion from cultural government, and under-funding of language and heritage programs. Indigenous leaders argue that the delayed progress towards land return and a lack of constitutional recognition are resulting in incremental forms of cultural

removal. While Australia is not currently a "theater of war", its case poses pressing questions to the Security Council on long-term structural violence and the responsibility of the international community in addressing cultural loss in peacebuilding and justice agendas.

The Armenian-Azerbaijani conflict over control of Nagorno-Karabakh persists long into the claims of cultural genocide, particularly since the 2020 armed conflict and 2023 Azerbaijani attack. After the expulsion of Armenian inhabitants from the area, reports were heard of destruction, defacement, or diversion of Armenian churches, cemeteries, and monuments. Azerbaijan has dismissed them as accusations, asserting that it keeps places of heritage intact, but consistently denying the United Nations Educational, Social, and Cultural Organization's entry to verify conditions for itself. For Armenians, this behavior forms part of a wider pattern of erasure echoing the trauma of the 1915 Armenian Genocide. Armenia brought the issue before the Security Council several times in 2020-2023, but geopolitical alignments, especially the roles of Turkey and Russia, have limited international intervention.

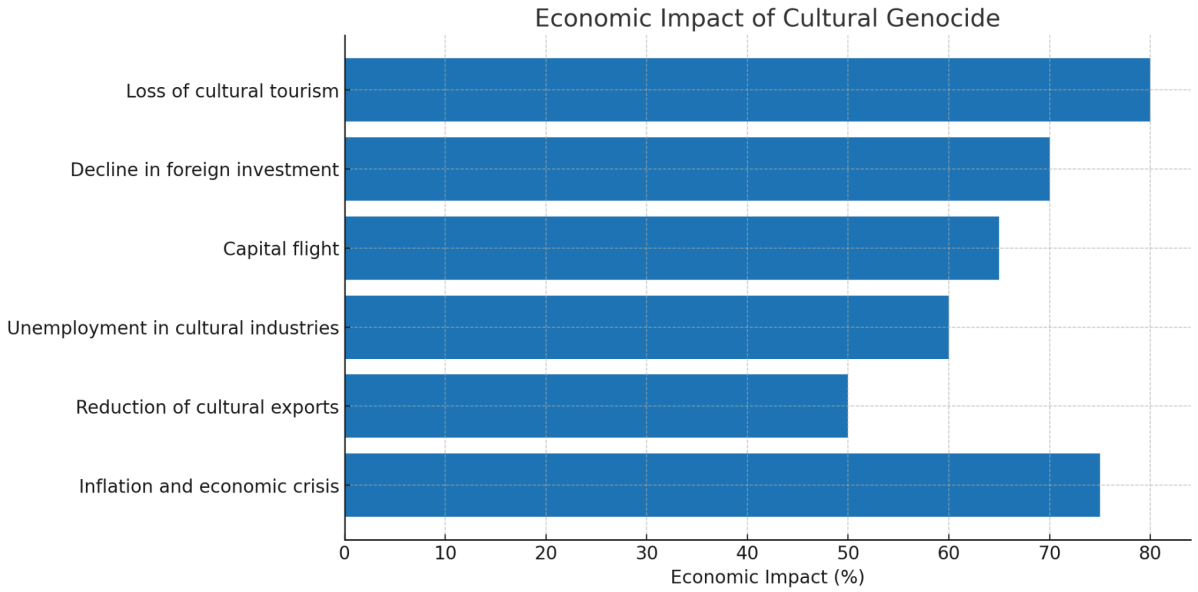
Social Impact

Cultural genocide has many consequences, but one of the most relevant ones is how this affects many communities. As time passes, people expect society to be better, but it has not. In recent years, the situation has not improved; the loss of culture is getting worse every day, and the social tissue is unraveling more and more over time.

Economic impact

There could be colossal negative changes in the economy of a country, for instance, the destruction of cultural infrastructure (such as museums, statues, and libraries) can directly affect the tourist sector. Additionally, it would require a huge investment in order to rebuild the missing cultural heritage. It could also impact the craft, music, dance, and gastronomy industries, since their survival depends directly on the preservation of the culture. Moreover, cultural genocide could lead to

economic destabilization, given that all the violence and political instability inevitably cause capital flight, the decline in foreign investment, and inflation.



Topic and the United Nations

In 2015, the General Assembly established December 9th as the International Day of Commemoration and Dignity of the Victims of the Crime of Genocide and of the Prevention of this Crime, in order to raise awareness in society.

One of the first international treaties addressing the crime of genocide was the Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide, adopted by the United Nations just after World War II. It meant a breakthrough for international law and the protection of human rights all over the world.

Since this document was created, it has had the intention of promoting a culture of peace education, social cohesion, and respect for diversity, collecting testimonies of victims and survivors, creating and maintaining archives, and contributing to reducing cases of genocide denial.

In addition to the Convention there are many other documents created with the same purpose like: the Resolution establishing the International Day for the Commemoration and Dignity of the Victims of the Crime of Genocide and for the Prevention of this Crime, Human Rights Council Resolution 28/24 on the Prevention of Genocide, United Nations resolutions on the prevention of genocide 2005 World Summit Outcome and the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) Declaration concerning the Intentional Destruction of Cultural Heritage.

In 2005, the World Summit was celebrated to create the document "Implementing the responsibility to protect", in which it is established that every state is responsible for protecting its population from genocide, war crimes, ethnic cleansing, and crimes against humanity.

However, it was also agreed that if the state is not fulfilling its responsibility, the international community must help build the capacity to protect at-risk populations before crises and conflicts erupt.

Besides, as a preventive measure, the United Nations has been using education about diversity, the holocaust, and other famous cases of genocide as an effective way to encourage reflection and to avoid future violent acts, through the International Holocaust and Genocide Education Program.

Moreover, in honor of the victims, the International Day of Remembrance for the Victims of the Holocaust (January 27) and the International Day of Reflection on the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi in Rwanda (April 7) were created. In those days, commemorative and cultural activities are organized to remember the violent past.

Since 2003, when the General Conference of the United Nations Educational, Scientific, and Cultural Organization was celebrated, the international community has been concerned about the increase in the number of acts of intentional destruction of cultural heritage.

Furthermore, the international community recommends joining the Convention for the Protection of Cultural Property in the Event of Armed Conflict (1954), since it is fundamental for the protection and preservation of the cultural legacy of humanity.

This document advocates taking measures both in times of peace and in times of armed conflict. In peacetime, the suggested actions to take are: using the official symbol of protection (blue shield) in order to identify the objects and sites protected by the convention, adopting preventive measures, such as designating safe havens to protect cultural property in the event of a conflict, and training and educating specialized personnel in the protection of cultural property.

Some of the most important measures to be taken in times of armed conflict include: prohibiting the use of cultural property for military purposes (such as the transport of troops, or any activity that could damage the property) and banning the export of cultural assets. If such assets are exported, their return to the state of origin must be demanded.

The United Nations still has some way to go in terms of labeling and sanctioning cultural genocide, since the United Nations' concept of "genocide" only considers it as a "crime perpetrated with intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnical, racial or religious group". Without considering cultural genocide as a crime, given that there is not always violence involved, therefore, it can not be punished the same way as a normal case of genocide.

Controversy points

Why is it a controversial topic?

Not only is cultural genocide under constant debate, but the very term "genocide" to this day continues to cause discussions and legal loopholes. There is a debate about the extent to which this is assimilation and the extent of cultural genocide. Policies such as banning native languages and traditional dress are often considered, mainly by government and figures involved, as assimilation policies aimed at creating national cohesion and preventing social fragmentation. However, it is a terrible mistake to ban free expression of cultural identity, as this incites resentment and rejection of cultures different from the established one.

Difficulty of action of international institutions

Survivors of violent events often find their cases dismissed as less significant unless the violence is officially catalogued as genocide. This is because international institutions respond more forcefully to genocide than to other categories like ethnic cleansing and internal violence. According to the United Nations, due to the exponential growth of armed conflicts, crimes against humanity, and potential cases of genocide worldwide, advocacy groups are appealing to the term genocide in the hopes of gaining support, resources and the world's attention.

However, according to the United Nations Genocide Convention, genocide is not only mass murder but also the intention to completely or partially eradicate ethnic, indigenous, national, or religious groups. This makes it very difficult to legally prove that genocide is being committed, even when atrocities are being carried out. There are

occasions when it is classified as crimes against humanity or armed conflict crimes when that intent cannot be proven.

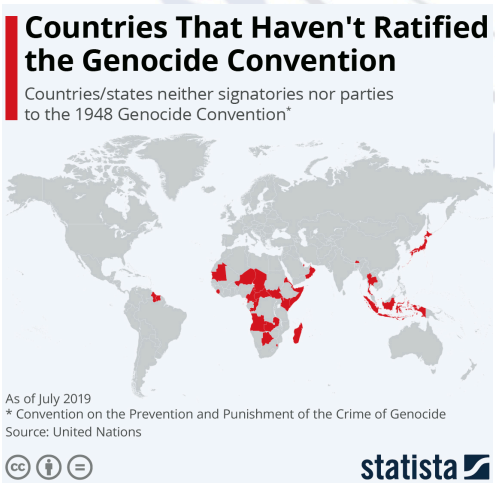
Many people believe genocide is the "worst" atrocity because of how it is portrayed by the media and history books. Nevertheless, in court, judges and prosecutors treat these crimes as equally serious under international law. Not for their cruelty level, but for specific legal criteria.

"War crimes", crimes against humanity, and genocide

There is often confusion about the concepts of crimes against humanity, "war crimes", and genocide. According to Amnesty International, the definitions of these terms are as follows.

1. Genocide is in whole or in part the intent of destroying a national, ethnic, religious, or racial group.
2. Crimes against humanity are crimes committed as part of a systematic attack against civilians, including inhuman treatment, murder, enslavement, and forced sexual intercourse.
3. "War crimes" are violations of international humanitarian law that include deliberate murders, attacks against civilians, use of poison, and attacks on hospitals and schools.

Postures on the topic



Some countries consider that what is referred to as "cultural genocide" is a real ongoing threat that should be taken care of as a priority among nations. They imply that the destruction of cultural identity and heritage is used as a strategy to wipe out entire ethnic groups, and that this creates instability, resentment, and even armed conflicts. On the other hand, many nations believe that the concept of "cultural genocide" is too politically influenced or subjective. While some countries push for stronger mechanisms to recognize and prevent cultural erasure, others prioritize national sovereignty and non-intervention, especially when the accusations are tied to internal affairs or territorial disputes.

Objectives

In this edition, the Security Council expects delegates to enrich their critical thinking and to be open to dialogue as a way to reach real solutions that can change the perception of global problems. Following the Security Council's main goal, which is to maintain peace and security worldwide. With a diplomatic posture when debating, always considering the principles of the United Nations, seeking common ground, and avoiding confrontation among delegations.

The Chair hopes every delegate does great research and makes a remarkable contribution to the debate to reach the most viable solutions. The points raised by all nations will be discussed in order to reach a common resolution by unanimous agreement.

Having explained this, the Security Council introduces some essential purposes of the topic:

1. Encourage the participation of affected communities in political decision-making.

2. Public policies that protect indigenous communities from abuse.

3. Government recognition of physical, cultural and moral damage to indigenous communities

4. Promote diversity and interest in other cultures in schools.

5. Take into account the possibility of economic compensation for the damage caused to indigenous communities.

6. Recognize the importance of cultural diversity for the maintenance of social cohesion.

7. Establish legal frameworks that safeguard cultural heritage.

8. Acknowledge cultural events and festivals to keep the culture alive.

9. Create spaces in which culture can be shared and practiced freely.

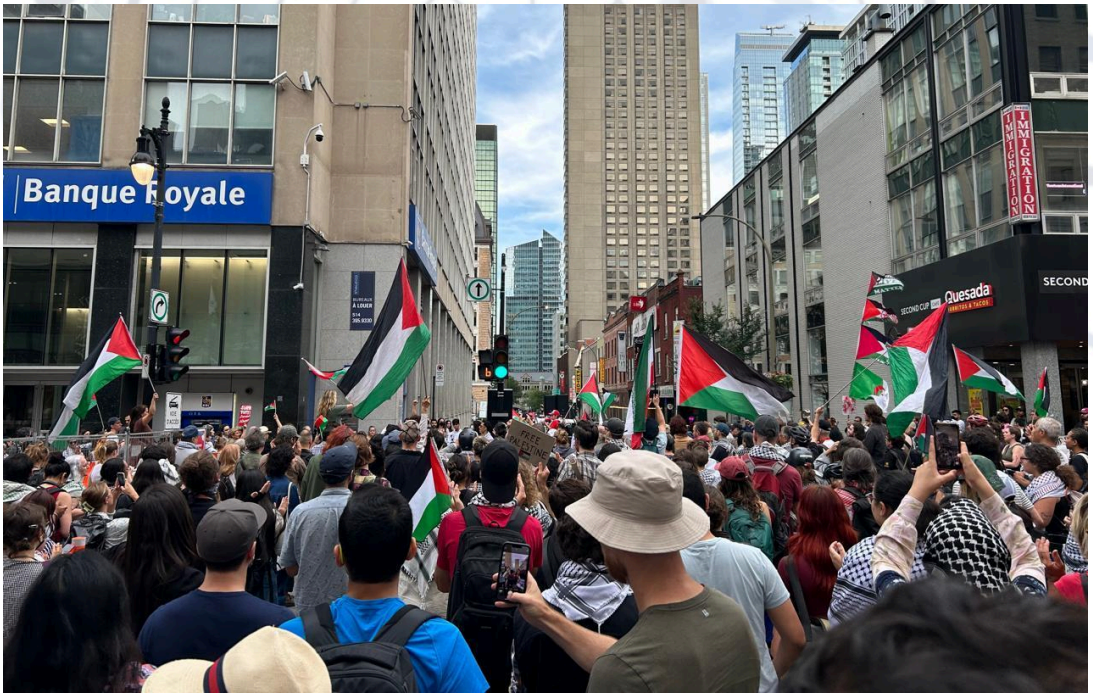
10. Support local artists and artisans whose work contributes to the preservation of identity.

Conclusion

Nowadays, the world is facing serious risks, such as the outbreak of a conflagration between dominant nations, climate change, and the ineffectiveness of international institutions to govern and guarantee peace in the world. International collaboration is vital to address and deal with cultural genocide.

It is such a complex and controversial issue that has a history of not being recognized by international institutions in charge of protecting human rights. It is an issue that needs to be discussed and made visible as culture is a fundamental part of society: it brings identity and belonging, which strengthens the social fabric.

The Chair looks forward to proposals that promote the reestablishment of the capacity of institutions for a new order can be addressed. Debate, discuss, and initiate actions, challenge, and innovate ideas that lead to paths of peace.



Hoping the present document provides you with relevant information in order to make a dynamic debate, in which all the delegations have the opportunity to speak their minds and be heard. In that manner, reach real solutions that work for all the present and future cases around the world. Therefore, it is of utmost importance that all commitment is reflected in the disposition. From the workshops until the last day of this model.

Additionally, we, as president, moderator, and secretary, would like to thank the delegates for the initiative and enthusiasm for being part of this committee and its topic, also for contributing to the seek for peace in the world.

Welcome to the Security Council.

"Mankind must put an end to war before war puts an end to mankind."
- John F. Kennedy.

Countries

State of Palestine:

More than 93 massacres have occurred since 2024, murdering 10,037 Palestinians, destroying 195 heritage sites, such as the Rafah Museum, El Mathaf al-Funduq, the Qasr Al-Basha, the Palestinian Artists' Union on Jalaa Street in Gaza City, and the famous clay pots that were fired in the city's al-Fawakhir district, among many others.

For that reason, the 1954 Hague Convention was created, so Palestinians and Israelis committed to protecting historical monuments from the ravages of armed conflicts. Nevertheless, over the years, this Convention has proven its lack of effectiveness; consequently, all these crimes were submitted to the International Court of Justice by South Africa, and supported by Malaysia, Turkey, Bolivia, Brazil, and other countries. In the statement, Israel is accused of genocide in its armed conflict in Gaza and an end to the brutal military attack is being demanded.

Ukraine:

Since 2022, the Russian Federation has been committing cultural genocide in Ukraine, arguing that: "Modern Ukraine was created completely and entirely by Russia, more specifically by Bolshevik and communist Russia, which is why it does not have the kind of rights the world associates with sovereign nations" (Vladimir Putin, 2022).

The ban on publishing books and magazines in the Ukrainian language, the creation of groups dedicated to the exile, imprisonment, or murder of influential intellectuals, and the destruction of cultural centers,

statues of great authors and libraries, are some of the most relevant Russian attempts to eradicate some important aspects of their culture, such as language and art.

Also, more than 19,384 children had been deported to Russia, prohibiting them from speaking Ukrainian and taking them to military training. Thenceforth, the International Criminal Court approved issuing arrest warrants against Russian President Vladimir Putin on charges of war crimes.

Democratic Republic of the Congo:

This territory counts with one of the biggest world reserves of metals, such as cobalt, copper, and zinc, which has encouraged other countries to participate in warlike conflicts to have access to those natural resources, causing one of the world's largest and deadliest humanitarian crises, with approximately six million victims.

In 2013, the Security Council approved the intervention of the offensive brigade under the mandate of the UN Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO), in the hope of fighting against M23 (March 23 Movement, a rebel group made

up of Tutsis). Unfortunately, in 2022, M23 resurfaced and gained control of large areas of North Kivu province.

In 2025, Rwanda and the Democratic Republic of Congo are set to sign an agreement in which both countries commit to respecting territorial integrity and prohibiting hostilities. However, some experts remain uneasy due to their concern about legitimizing the plundering of Congolese natural resources and sacrificing justice to guarantee a fragile peace.

People's Republic of China

Since 1951, the People´s Republic of China has been committing cultural genocide in the Tibet Autonomous Region: separating children from their families to educate them in boarding schools, assimilating them into their culture and imposing Mandarin as the language; making

Buddhist monks disappear, while the inhabitants of this region are deprived of their rights of expression, electronically monitored and ultimately imprisoned for criticizing Beijing.

Therefore, Tsering, leader of the Tibetan Central Administration, seeks greater autonomy for Tibet, calling for sanctions against China for human rights violations.

Countries in G5:

1. French Republic
2. People's Republic of China
3. Russian Federation
4. United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland
5. United States of America

Members of the organization

6. Federal Republic of Somalia
7. Hellenic Republic
8. Islamic Republic of Pakistan
9. Kingdom of Denmark
10. Republic of Panama.

Countries invited to the debate and listening countries:

11. Arab Republic of Egypt
12. Canada
13. Democratic Republic of the Congo
14. Federative Republic of Brazil
15. Islamic Republic of Iran
16. Kingdom of Saudi Arabia
17. Republic of Argentina
18. Republic of Armenia
19. Republic of India
20. Republic of Indonesia
21. Republic of the Philippines
22. Republic of Poland
23. Republic of Rwanda
24. Republic of Serbia
25. Republic of South Africa
26. Republic of Türkiye
27. State of Israel
28. State of Palestine
29. Syrian Arab Republic
30. Ukraine
31. United Mexican States

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"Those who believe in the world are the ones meant to change it."

President: Ana Victoria Corona Neumaier
Secretary: Isabella Zorrilla Romera
Moderator: Aranza Romero García

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